



THE ZCASH CEREMONY

037 / 22-23 OCT 2016 / ZCASH / UNCOMMON

ONE HONEST WITNESS

Before Zcash could launch, its first shielded protocol needed public parameters. On 22-23 October 2016, six witnesses used multi-party computation to produce the proving and verifying keys for Sprout. The network launched on 28 October, several days after the ceremony.

The setup's secret byproducts were called toxic waste: combined, they could enable counterfeit Zcash. Under the protocol's assumptions, one honest, uncompromised participant securely destroying their private contribution was enough to prevent reconstruction. Recovering the combined secret required every participant to be dishonest or compromised. This did not remove all trust or rule out other software and cryptographic flaws.

The witnesses worked in separate geographic locations, with offline compute machines and removed wireless radios. Write-once DVDs carried messages across the air gap and preserved evidence. Cryptographic security depended on physical precautions as well as mathematics.

The six participants were Zooko Wilcox, Andrew Miller, Peter Van Valkenburgh, Derek Hinch, Peter Todd and Edward Snowden. Snowden took part under the name John Dobberty; his role became public in 2022. Todd's account records further hardware destruction on 24 October, after the computation had finished.

Here, all six gather around an imagined altar as a Zcash coin rises into light. The shared room and magical apparatus are symbolic staging. Separate stations and successive phases become one image: the public result comes together, while the private material must not survive.

DETAILS IN THE ART

01 SIX WITNESSES AND CRYSTALS

Six figures and six separate crystals stand for the six contributions. The light joining them is an invented metaphor for the shared public result, not a depiction of real equipment.

02 THE DVD-R

The disc and labelled sleeve recall the write-once media that carried messages between offline compute nodes and networked machines, preserving an evidence trail.

03 THE DETACHED RADIO

The generic circuit board beside the laptop represents removal of Wi-Fi and Bluetooth hardware. It is a visual shorthand, not an exact model of a ceremony component.

04 THE BROKEN REMNANTS

The jar evokes destruction of hardware that might retain secrets. Todd dismantled and heated electronic components on 24 October; the jar combines that later phase with the ceremony, rather than documenting a real container.

05 THE SPROUT CARVING

The two-leaf motif identifies Zcash's original shielded protocol. The altar, floating coin and glowing crystals are fictional; no physical coin was summoned during the historical event.

SOURCE & ART NOTE

Sources: [ceremony record](#); [ECC design account](#); [Sprout launch date](#); [Todd's account](#); [Snowden confirmation](#). Cast: back left Wilcox, back centre Miller, back right Van Valkenburgh; front left Hinch, middle right Todd, front right Snowden. Public portraits informed stylised likenesses; several are later or undated, so these are not exact 2016 appearances. ONE HONEST WITNESS is editorial wording, not a quotation.